

Emotions Are Data

Emotional Intelligence and Personal Accountability



Name: _____

Date: _____



Before reacting, pause and check:

☐

Identify what I'm feeling (name the emotion)

☐

Ask: Is this stress (internal) or pressure (external)?

☐

Notice if my body is in "fight, flight or freeze"

☐

Engage my thinking brain (neo cortex) before responding

☐

Choose a response instead of reacting

Understanding Emotional Signals at Work

Why this matters:

Emotions are not the problem, they are information

Emotions can influence:

- communication
- decision-making
- collaboration
- conflict resolution
- professional reputation

By interpreting emotions we can:

- have better judgement
- greater self-control
- stronger relationships
- improved accountability

The Brain's Three Layers

1. Brain Stem ("Reptile Brain")

- controls survival function (breathing, heart rate)
- activates flight, fight or freeze

2. Limbic System ("Emotional Brain")

- process emotion
- forms emotional memories
- includes the amygdala

3. Neo Cortex ("Thinking Brain")

- reasoning and analysis
- planning and decision-making
- language and impulse control

Amygdala hijack: when the amygdala perceives danger, it can override logical thinking.

Stress vs Pressure

Stress:

- internal
- fears, doubts, insecurity
- unique to the individual

Pressure:

- external
- deadlines, expectations, performance demands
- often shared across teams



Negativity Bias

Our brains are wired to:

- notice criticism faster than praise
- assume threat before safety
- prepare for worse-case outcomes

Bias that once supported survival can now lead to:

- catastrophizing
- misreading tone
- overreacting to feedback
- assuming negative intent

Reacting vs Responding

Reacting may look like:

- sending a tense email
- interrupting
- shutting down
- raising your voice
- defensive posture

Responding may look like:

- pausing before speaking
- naming the emotion
- checking assumptions
- asking clarifying questions
- choosing professional language



Emotional Signals Are Not Universal

Includes:

- direct eye contact
- silence
- loud enthusiasm
- reserved tone

Note: These may signal different emotions depending on cultural norms

Responsibility vs Accountability

Responsibility

- assigned duties
- can be delegated
- appears in job descriptions

Accountability

- owning outcomes
- can't be delegated
- may require emotional maturity
- often occurs after action



Instead of Flight, Fight or Freeze

Practice: Regroup, Reflect and Respond



Activity 1

Reflect on your own language use,
and answer the following
questions in the spaces provided.

**RECALL A RECENT SITUATION AS WORK OR YOUR DAILY LIFE WHEN EMOTIONS ROSE.
WHAT HAPPENED?**

**HOW DID YOUR EMOTIONS SHAPE YOUR RESPONSE IN THAT MOMENT?
WHAT MIGHT HAVE CHANGED IF YOU HAD PAUSED BEFORE ACTING?**

ACTIVITY:

React or Respond?

 **Objective:** Match each workplace situation with the most thoughtful response from the Phrase Bank

For each match, decide:

- Is the tone reactive or regulated?
- Is the response direct or softened?
- What format is this best suited for (in person, email, or message)?

Instructions

1. Read the workplace situations below.
2. Match each one with the best response from the Phrase Bank.
3. For each match, decide:
 - Is the tone reactive or regulated?
 - Is it direct or softened?
 - What format fits best (in person, email, or text/message)?
4. Optional: Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

PHRASE BANK: Use each phrase once

- A. "I'd like to clarify something before we move forward. Can we walk through your concern?"
- B. "I want to give this the right attention. I'll review it carefully and respond tomorrow."
- C. "I'm feeling a bit caught off guard. Can I take a moment to gather my thoughts?"
- D. "It would help me if we could let each other finish before responding."
- E. "This feels urgent. Can we confirm what's most important right now so I can prioritize?"

MATCH THE PHRASE TO THE SITUATION

Workplace Situations

1. During a team meeting, a colleague publicly questions the quality of your work and suggests it may delay the project. You feel defensive and surprised.

Phrase Bank choice:

☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐ E

Is the tone

☐ Reactive ☐ Regulated

Is it:

What format is this?

☐ Direct ☐ Softened

☐ In person ☐ Email ☐ Text/Message

Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

2. You receive a detailed critique of your proposal in an email at 9:30 PM. You are tired and feel misunderstood.

Phrase Bank choice:

☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐ E

Is the tone

☐ Reactive ☐ Regulated

Is it:

What format is this?

☐ Direct ☐ Softened

☐ In person ☐ Email ☐ Text/Message

Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

MATCH THE PHRASE TO THE SITUATION

Workplace Situations

3. Your manager changes the deadline unexpectedly and says, "We need this done ASAP." You're already managing multiple priorities and feel overwhelmed.

Phrase Bank choice:

☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐ E

Is the tone

☐ Reactive ☐ Regulated

Is it:

☐ Direct ☐ Softened

What format is this?

☐ In person ☐ Email ☐ Text/Message

Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

4. A teammate interrupts you several times while you're explaining an idea, cutting you off before you finish your point.

Phrase Bank choice:

☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐ E

Is the tone

☐ Reactive ☐ Regulated

Is it:

☐ Direct ☐ Softened

What format is this?

☐ In person ☐ Email ☐ Text/Message

Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

MATCH THE PHRASE TO THE SITUATION

Workplace Situations

5. In a discussion about a new process, someone raises a concern but speaks vaguely. You're unsure what the real issue is and sense tension in the room.

Phrase Bank choice:

☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D ☐ E

Is the tone

☐ Reactive ☐ Regulated

Is it:

What format is this?

☐ Direct ☐ Softened

☐ In person ☐ Email ☐ Text/Message

Rewrite the phrase using your own natural speaking or writing style.

MATCH THE PHRASE TO THE SITUATION

Workplace Situations Answer Key

Situation	Phrase	Tone	Direct or Softened	Format
1	C	Regulated	Softened	In Person
2	B	Regulated	Direct	Email
3	E	Regulated	Direct	In Person
4	D	Regulated	Softened	In Person
5	A	Regulated	Direct	In Person

ACTIVITY 3:

From Trigger to Response Plan

Step 1: Identify Your Pattern

When I feel triggered at work, I tend to:

- ☐ Speak quickly
- ☐ Defend myself
- ☐ Withdraw or shut down
- ☐ Over-explain
- ☐ Send messages too quickly
- ☐ Avoid the conversation
- ☐ Other:

Step 2: Identify Your Most Common Trigger

My most common emotional trigger at work is:

- ☐ Public criticism
- ☐ Tight deadlines
- ☐ Feeling excluded
- ☐ Miscommunication
- ☐ Perceived unfairness
- ☐ Sudden change
- ☐ Other:

ACTIVITY 3:

From Trigger to Response Plan

Step 3: Build Your Regulation Strategy

Next time this trigger happens, I will:

- ☐ Pause before responding
- ☐ Take one breath
- ☐ Ask a clarifying question
- ☐ Delay my response
- ☐ Name the emotion silently
- ☐ Request time to reflect

Write the exact sentence you will use:

Step 4: Consider the Impact

If I respond intentionally instead of reacting automatically, it may improve:

- ☐ Trust
- ☐ Team morale
- ☐ My credibility
- ☐ My clarity
- ☐ My leadership presence

One outcome I want to protect is: